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The News Within the News

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Schools should take teen phones during the day to curb social media addiction, AG says

The Charlotte Observer reports that North Carolina Attorney General Josh Stein is encouraging schools to take away smartphones from students during the school day to try to curb social media addiction.

Stein and the Wake County school system are among the groups who've joined federal class-action lawsuits accusing social media companies of creating a mental health crisis and exploiting young people for financial gain.

"When I talk about taking phones away from kids at the start of the day, it's not to take away their phones so they don't get it back," Stein said to applause from the audience. "There is an an appropriate time to do social media and during the school day is not that time."

Stein said that he expected to hear that students were in an uproar in the schools that took away their phones. Instead, Stein said leaders at those schools told him students liked it because they knew no one else was online so they weren't missing anything.

The schools also reported that students were now paying much more attention to the teacher instead of using their phones to go on social media, he said.

Attack by 9-foot gator ends with fisherman airlifted to hospital, Florida officials say

The Charlotte Observer reports that a fisherman was airlifted to a Florida hospital after being attacked by a 9-foot alligator, officials said.

First responders received a call of a "severe animal bite" shortly before 4:30 p.m. on March 10, according to Sarah Lux, a spokesperson for Lake County Fire Rescue.

A man was fishing in Pennbrooke Fairways, a small subdivision and golf course in Leesburg, when he encountered the gator, Lux said in an email to McClatchy News.

The gator bit him and left him with injuries to his hand and wrist, a spokesperson for the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission told McClatchy News.

The man was airlifted to a trauma center in Orlando for treatment, Lux said.

A nuisance alligator trapper and an officer with the conservation commission responded to the location and removed the male gator, which measured 9 feet, 3 inches long, officials said.

Police officers who laughed at veteran denied restroom get written reprimands

The Dallas Morning News reports that Dallas police officials handed down written reprimands Tuesday to four

officers seen on video mocking a disabled veteran who urinated on himself after he was denied the restroom.

The department's assistant chief over patrol, Reuben Ramirez, decided on the officers' discipline after an afternoon hearing with the officers and other commanders. Police also decided to mandate sensitivity training for the officers, officials said.

Department spokeswoman Kristin Lowman would not release the findings or discipline, instead referring a reporter to file an open records request. She declined to comment further.

The discipline came after months of pressure from Dallas' civilian police watchdogs and four days after The Dallas Morning News published an investigation detailing how the oversight office that brought veteran DyNell Lane's case to light lost its authority to investigate complaints and its control over what grievances could be reviewed.

A written reprimand is a form of formal discipline the department hands down that will go into the officers' files but won't, by default, affect their pay or status.

Drag show ban at university left intact by Supreme Court

Bloomberg News reports that the US Supreme Court refused to let a student group host a charity drag show at a public university in Texas, siding with a school official who banned the performance as "derisive, divisive and demoralizing."

In a one-sentence order that didn't note any dissents, the high court turned away a request from an LGBTQ-rights group that said West Texas A&M University and its president violated the Constitution's free speech clause by barring the planned March 22 show from taking place on campus.

As is its usual practice with its emergency docket, the court didn't explain its decision. The order comes amid a wave of controversies about speech rights on college campuses around the country.

The group, Spectrum WT, sued after West Texas A&M President Walter Wendler barred the show last year. In a letter to the university community, Wendler said drag shows denigrate women, likening them to "blackface" minstrel shows.

Spectrum WT told the Supreme Court that Wendler's ban was emblematic of a nationwide problem, exacerbated by campus discord over the Israel-Hamas conflict, abortion and other divisive issues.

"Public university and college officials nationwide from across the political spectrum are appointing themselves censors-in-chief, separating what they consider 'good' from 'bad' expression on their campuses," the group argued.

California schools could ban Flamin' Hot Cheetos under new bill

The Los Angeles Times reports that the days of Flamin' Hot Cheetos in California schools may be numbered.

A new bill aims to ban from public schools food products that contain artificial dyes, including the ingredient that makes Cheetos pop with their signature yellow and red colors.

Lawmakers argue that developing young minds are harmed by the chemical ingredients and that federal guidelines have not been updated in decades.

Assembly Bill 2316 takes aim at six synthetic food dyes -- blue 1, blue 2, green 3, red 40, yellow 5 and yellow 6 -- as well as coloring agent titanium dioxide, ingredients commonly used to artificially tint foods including candy, as well as drinks and some medications and vitamins.

Red 40 and yellow 6 are found in Takis, Doritos and Flamin' Hot Cheetos, the main culprits that turn snack lovers'

fingers a powdery crimson. Blue 1 is found in Froot Loops, and other artificial dyes can be found in Jolly Ranchers, M&Ms, Sour Patch Kids and Mountain Dew.

Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, introduced the bill and emphasized this is not an outright ban of any specific products, but of those chemical ingredients.

A 2021 study from the California Environmental Protection Agency found that consuming synthetic food dyes could lead to hyperactivity and other neurological behavior in some children.

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